hard enough at school. I think he wanted me to become a doctor or something, because on particularly angry days, he used to warn: 'Even if you don't have the capacity to walk, even if your back fails you, you can still sit on a chair at a desk and prescribe medicine.' Clearly, he wasn't a believer in my passion for cricket. Not in those early days.

My father had his reasons to be sceptical about a career in cricket. I was born in Tirah, Maidan, a valley in the mountains of Khyber. It is a remote area in the northwest region of Pakistan and home to my fellow Afridi tribesmen. Traditionally, the Afridis, who are divided into several sub-tribes, have enjoyed the reputation of fighting everyone, be it the Mughals or the British. We have defended the famous Khyber Pass for hundreds of years and have a can-do-anything reputation when it comes to protecting our land.

The Afridi tribe lives on both sides of the Pakistan–Afghanistan border, an area that has witnessed a lot of fighting and terrorist activities in recent decades. When my immediate family was living there, terrorism wasn't rampant. But fights and feuds were common and that made them move to Tangibanda in Kohat, another hub of Afridi tribesmen. Kohat is also a part of the unruly northwest, but it's located more towards the mainland and is therefore less volatile as a region.

Migrating was easy. It's in our blood. All Pashtuns take pride in being warring tribesmen. But we also have a very strong work ethic and always go where work requires us to. It's true: we Pashtuns love to work. We are up for any sort of labour. In Pakistan, Pashtuns dominate the construction and transportation industries, and also make up a good chunk of the army. Our hardiness is an asset that has made us the finest bricklayers and the toughest soldiers. That's why it is said that when a Pashtun isn't working, he's fighting.

In the precarious '80s, as the global superpowers faced off in Afghanistan and Pakistan's tribal areas became the frontline for what would become the longest war of our time, there wasn't much work in Kohat. In search of a living, my father shifted to Karachi, Pakistan's largest city and the 'promised land' for many Pashtuns because of its free, entrepreneurial spirit. Once he was fairly settled in Karachi, he brought the rest of us there.

My father started off humbly in the city. Karachi has always had a water-shortage problem and he joined the water-tanker business, supplying water to those who could afford it. Along the way he received some help from cousins and friends, as is the Pashtun way of networking within the family. A couple of years later, he got into car sales and started dealing in used and new cars. He set up what they call in Karachi a 'showroom', and in Peshawar a 'bargain'. Despite their hardiness, trade comes easily to Pashtuns, especially Afridis. My father kept on expanding the business and even invested in a bunch of small ventures here and there. By the end of a decade in Karachi, we weren't doing too badly for a middle-class family in a middle-class neighbourhood.

And then rushed in the military. My paternal uncle, Colonel Akram Afridi, was a decorated infantry officer of the 19th Baloch Regiment. As my father never had the time for sports, 'Kaka' Akram must be credited for introducing sports to our family. He had seen the world outside Tirah and Kohat, having been posted all over Pakistan. In the army, he had played some cricket and volleyball, the latter being a typically army sport – soldiers would set up a net anywhere and play. When he would come back on vacation to our village, he played cricket with my other uncles and relatives. Cricket was like a gift he brought with him every time he visited. That's how I picked up the game, in the mountains of northwest Pakistan, thanks to an exposed, well-